

- The narratives are centred around real people, but through re-presentation, a **representation of reality** is constructed focusing specifically on the challenges that the athletes face. The filming, editing and audio codes combine to construct a representation of this social group, raising awareness and creating positive representations of the Paralympians as athletes first, rather than disabled people ‘doing their best’.
- In constructing the representations as they have in *Super. Human.*, the producers have aimed to avoid the stereotypes of disabled athletes as having to ‘overcome’ their disability in order to achieve success, instead celebrating them as high-performance athletes in their own right.
- Consider how the representations are constructed through media language. **Close-up shots** of the athletes and their challenges during training and their home lives create positive representations of ordinary people who eat their breakfast, give birth, and play the drums, with whom the **audience** can positively associate. The fast-paced editing enables the advertisement to highlight a range of narratives and athletes with different disabilities, disciplines, and challenges.

Consider theoretical perspectives: Stuart Hall’s theory of representation

According to Hall, meanings are communicated through signs. This is very true of the advertising form where easily recognisable signs rapidly communicate meaning to an audience in a short space of time. For example, expressions of endurance and struggle are easily recognisable and understood.

This advertisement goes some way to address Hall’s assertions that stereotyping occurs when there are inequalities of power, and that excluded groups, such as the disabled, are constructed as different. In the advertisement, the focus is on the athletes as ordinary sports men and women striving to achieve a goal. The athletes are three dimensional and distinct from each other; therefore, the advertisement avoids simplifying their representations.

David Gauntlett’s theory of identity

In addressing an under-represented social group, the advertisement gives visible recognition to those with disabilities and allows disabled people to see themselves represented positively in the media.

Super. Human. offers audiences a more **diverse and inclusive range of identities** and broadens general understanding of what it means to be disabled as an athlete and in everyday life.

However, many would argue that the Paralympics in itself is not enough to redress the balance and indeed, many disabilities are not featured in the games.

PART 3: STARTING POINTS – Audiences

The target audience for this advertisement is a relatively broad demographic, including Channel 4 viewers who largely fall into the 16–34 age bracket; fans of sport; and those who desire to see more inclusive representations of social groups, of which they may be a member, from a channel whose remit states that it ‘appeals to the tastes and interests of a culturally diverse society’ (www.ofcom.org.uk).

Consider how the advertisement targets, reaches and addresses its audience.

- The use of **personalisation** will reach the audience. *Super.Human.* deals with real, human stories focusing on the day-to-day struggles of being an athlete in training and disabled. The individual narratives are constructed to encourage the audience to identify with the athletes and their lives.
- The **technical codes** include a lot of close-up shots, some of which are uncomfortable, for example, the popping of the blister. It also gives the audience access to views with which they may be unfamiliar, such as the attaching of a prosthetic blade, all of which hold their attention. The editing cuts between the athletes’ gruelling routines and clips of cartoon moments, lightening the mood and engaging the audience through humour.
- The **audio codes** address the audience. The soundtrack is a recognisable song from the musical Bugsy Malone, *So You Want To Be a Boxer*. The choice of this upbeat, stirring tune grabs the audience’s attention with its connotations of struggle and hard work paying off. Older audiences will be familiar with the film from which it is taken. Other audio codes suggest struggle, heavy breathing and grunting and these are juxtaposed with sounds from